

native to tropical Africa and Asia, has been used medicinally since the earliest times, and is taken for indigestion, dysentery, and other gastrointestinal problems.

Ocimum basilicum (Lamiaceae) Sweet Basil, Basil

Description Strongly aromatic annual growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has shiny oval leaves, a square stem, and small white flowers in whorls.

Habitat & Cultivation Sweet basil, also known as basil, is probably native to India. Over 150 varieties are now grown around the world for their distinctive flavor and essential oil. The leaves and flowering tops are gathered as the plant comes into flower.

Parts Used Leaves, flowering tops, essential oil.

Constituents Sweet basil contains a volatile oil (about 1%), which consists principally of linalool and methylchavicol, along with small quantities of methyl cinnamate, cineole, and other terpenes.

History & Folklore In his 1st-century CE *Materia Medica*, the Greek physician Dioscorides described the African belief that eating sweet basil stopped the pain caused by a scorpion's sting. The herb was used in Roman times to relieve flatulence, to counteract poisoning, as a diuretic, and to stimulate breast-milk production. Basil also has a history of use in Ayurvedic medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sweet basil acts principally on the digestive and nervous systems, easing flatulence, stomach cramps, colic, and indigestion. It can be used to prevent or relieve nausea and vomiting, and helps to kill intestinal worms. Sweet basil

has a mildly sedative action, proving useful in treating nervous irritability, depression, anxiety, and difficulty in sleeping. It may also be taken for epilepsy, migraine, and whooping cough. The herb has been traditionally taken to increase breast-milk production. Applied externally, sweet basil leaves act as an insect repellent. The juice from the leaves brings relief to insect bites and stings. Sweet basil has an established antibacterial action.

Related Species See also holy basil (*Ocimum tenuiflorum*, p. 116). Bush basil (*O. basilicum* var. *minimum*) has a much milder action than sweet basil, and is used to relieve cramping pain and flatulence.

Caution Sweet basil essential oil should not be taken internally.

Self-help Use Minor bites, stings & swellings, p. 303.

Oenothera biennis (Onagraceae) Evening Primrose

Description Biennial herb growing to 8 in (20 cm). Has red blotches on stem, crinkled lance-shaped leaves, 4-petaled yellow flowers, and elongated seed capsules.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to North America, evening primrose is now commonly found in many temperate zones around the world. It thrives in open areas, especially in dunes and sandy soil. Evening primrose is grown commercially for its seed oil.

Parts Used Leaves, stem bark, flowers, seed oil.

Constituents Evening primrose oil is rich in essential fatty acids—linoleic (about 70%) and gammalinolenic acid (about 9%) in particular. Its action mostly depends on the gammalinolenic acid (GLA), which is a precursor of prostaglandin E₁. The oil is often combined with vitamin E to prevent oxidation.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The flowers, leaves, and stem bark of evening primrose have astringent and sedative properties. All three parts have been employed in the treatment of whooping cough. Evening primrose has also been taken for digestive problems and asthma, and used as a poultice to ease the discomfort of rheumatic disorders. The oil, applied externally, is beneficial in the treatment of eczema, certain other itchy skin conditions, and breast tenderness. Taken internally, the oil has an effect in lowering blood pressure, and in preventing the clumping of platelets. The oil is now commonly taken for premenstrual problems, including tension and abdominal bloating, and

may prove helpful in conditions as diverse as dry eyes and multiple sclerosis.

Caution Do not take evening primrose oil if suffering from epilepsy.

Olea europaea (Oleaceae) Olive

Description Evergreen tree growing to 33 ft (10 m). Has a deeply grooved gray trunk, small leathery leaves, clusters of small greenish-white flowers, and a green fruit ripening to black.



Olive harvesting is carried out in many groves much as it was centuries ago.

Habitat & Cultivation Olive trees grow wild in the Mediterranean region and are cultivated in Mediterranean countries and in regions with a similar climate in the Americas. The leaves may be gathered throughout the year; the fruit in late summer. The leaves of wild trees are believed to contain a higher concentration of active principles.

Parts Used Leaves, oil.

Constituents Olive leaves contain oleoropine, cholesterol, and leine. Olive oil contains about 75% oleic acid, a monounsaturated fatty acid.

History & Folklore The olive was probably first cultivated in Crete around 3500 BCE. The tree has many symbolic associations: the olive branch is an emblem of peace, and the leaves crowned victors in the ancient Olympic Games. The leaves have been used since those times to clean wounds. The oil has been used for ritual anointing in some religions.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Olive leaves lower blood pressure and help to improve the function of the circulatory system. They are also mildly diuretic and may be used to treat conditions such as cystitis. Possessing some ability to lower blood-sugar levels, the leaves have been taken for diabetes. The oil is nourishing and improves the balance of fats within the blood. It is traditionally taken with lemon juice in teaspoonful doses to treat gallstones. The oil has a generally protective action on the digestive tract and is useful for dry skin.



Evening primrose



Sweet basil is a mildly sedative herb with antibacterial properties.